held onto me. I asked her if she was nervous: ‘No.’

I had to smile.

‘Well, there’s 65,000 people out there in the stadium waiting for us, hoping we’re going to get to the World Cup. If you’re not nervous, you must be the only person here who isn’t.’

‘No, I’m not. I’m not nervous.’

She looked up at me and gave me that smile and that was enough to tell me she was fine. We walked out into the roar and the sunshine. The cameras were on Kirsty all the way to the center spot. I hardly needed to ask if she was okay. She was just so graceful and so poised.

I wish us players could have been as relaxed as she was: the coolest person inside Old Trafford. She was great.

Since that afternoon, Kirsty and I, and Victoria too, have become really good friends. We help her with fundraising whenever we can but I wouldn’t want anyone to think that’s all our relationship is about. Kirsty’s an amazing person, so full of life and energy. When you’re with her, you don’t think about what’s wrong with her or the fact that she’s hanging on for her life against all the odds. You see past that cylinder, past what you might call her disability. You see her personality, her determination to make a difference for other people, her happiness in the face of it all. She’s the bravest person I know. I remember the summer of the 2002 Commonwealth Games in Manchester when I ran with the baton into the stadium and met up with Kirsty before the two of us met The Queen. All the way round the running track, I was convinced the flame on the baton would blow out, or my tracksuit bottoms would slip down, or I’d trip on a trainer lace. As soon as I was face to face with Kirsty, though, all the nerves disappeared. Suddenly, it was this private moment, as if it was just the two of us in the stadium together: you look into her eyes and what comes back to you is calmness and inspiration. Kirsty’s smile takes you out of your own world and into hers, where she takes it all in her stride. *England captain? Her Majesty the Queen? Thousands of people watching in the stands? Pleased to meet you, I’m Kirsty Howard and this is all just fine by me.*

That’s how it was as we made our way to the halfway line at Old Trafford. I’d been fretting all week. Suddenly, I wasn’t thinking about the game at all. I wasn’t thinking about how big the occasion was or how desperately we wanted to win. I just wanted to be sure Kirsty was all right, walking beside